CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

JUNIOR SOFTWARE DEVELOPER IN THE AI ERA

Can a robot take this job? It took the junior's task list. The career is still standing. The ladder didn't disappear — the first rung moved. This guide shows where it is now.

★ **TL;DR — YES TO SOFTWARE ENGINEERING. NO TO A $20K BOOTCAMP AND A PRAYER. PROOF BEATS PAPER: TWO REAL PROJECTS OUTWEIGH ANY CERTIFICATE.** ★

FROM THE VIDEO — MASHA'S VERDICT

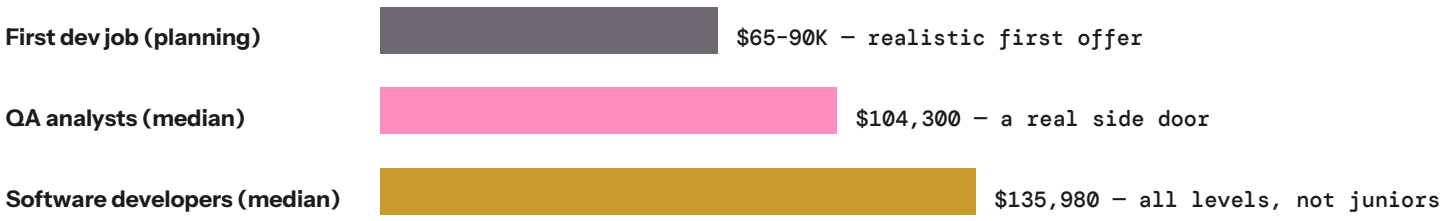
HER VERDICT: YES, WITH A HARD CONDITION — "Would I still learn software engineering in 2027? Yes. Would I pay 20K for a bootcamp and expect someone to hire me just because I learned Python? Absolutely not. That era is getting cooked."

HER SCORES · ENTRY 8/10 · MONEY 9/10 · CEILING 10/10 · AI EFFECT: SHRINK AT JUNIOR LEVEL

- Three roads, honestly priced by her: the classic road ~ 4 years for a CS degree; the fast road — a bootcamp, 4–12 months, often $10–20K; self-taught — almost free, except your teachers are "YouTube, Reddit, and a guy named Kevin screaming in a Discord server."
- "AI can already write basic code, fix bugs, create tests, explain errors — and guess who used to do a lot of that? The junior."
- Her pipeline paradox: companies want experienced developers, but "experienced developers do not magically reproduce in the server room. Somebody has to be a junior first."
- Her pay read: entry level ~$70–90K, experienced developers well over $100K. Checked: consistent with the sources below.
- Her conclusion: "Software engineering is not dying, but the first step into it is getting way harder."

Her words from the Career Glitch short — checked against the sources below.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



Read the bars honestly: the BLS median of $135,980 covers all experience levels — a first junior offer is nowhere near it. Indeed's entry-level average is ~$76–82K; plan on $65–90K for job #1. The occupation still grows +10% with ~106,100 openings a year (BLS) — but Stanford payroll data shows employment of developers aged 22–25 down ~20% from its 2022 peak, through reduced hiring, not firing. Both facts are true at once. See the official numbers

WHAT DOES A JUNIOR DEVELOPER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ writes code, fixes bugs, builds small features in a real codebase
- ✓ reviews AI output line by line — catching the plausible-but-wrong code is now a core junior skill
- ✓ learns the unglamorous stack: Git, tests, code review, "works on my machine" mysteries

Think: an apprentice in a workshop that just bought power tools. The tools do the cutting. You still have to know what to build — and notice when the cut is wrong.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Boilerplate and scaffolding, standard CRUD features, form-and-endpoint glue. First-pass bug fixes and "explain this error". Unit-test generation, documentation drafts, comments. That list used to be the junior job description.	System thinking — breaking an ambiguous problem into parts and seeing how a change ripples. Debugging production reality in messy legacy code. Verification and judgment: security, data integrity, "this looks right but isn't". Product context — why the feature exists at all.

⚠ NEW GRADS ARE NOW ~7% OF BIG TECH HIRES (SIGNALFIRE) AND JUNIOR POSTINGS FELL 14–15% VS SENIOR ONES AFTER CHATGPT (IZA / LIGHTCAST).
PLAN A 3–6 MONTH FIRST JOB SEARCH — NOT 3–6 WEEKS.

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ laptop, puzzles, meetings, more laptop (her words) ✓ proof > paper: GitHub and deployed projects are the credential ✓ AI fluency is expected on day one — hiding AI use is the red flag now	✗ the old tutorial → certificate → job pipeline ✗ guaranteed by any bootcamp or degree ✗ only "junior developer" postings — QA automation and support engineering are real doors ✗ the $136K median as your first salary

Good fit? You love puzzles, and you have the self-discipline to ship finished projects without a teacher standing over you.
Bad fit? You need external structure but plan to "just self-teach" — that combination fails silently. Take the structured route or a degree instead.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — SELF-TAUGHT	DOOR B — BOOTCAMP
$0–$500 · 6–18 months of discipline. freeCodeCamp, Harvard CS50, The Odin Project — all free. Nobody verifies your learning, so the portfolio IS the credential. Highest variance: brilliant for self-starters, silent failure for everyone else.	Average tuition ~ $13.6K (range $10–20K) · 3–6 months full-time. ~79% of alumni report a programming job within 6 months (Course Report, self-reported; audited figures run lower, ~64–78%). It buys structure and a deadline. It does not buy a job.

Smart move: the route matters less than the proof. A self-taught candidate with two deployed, documented projects beats a bootcamp graduate holding a certificate and a tutorial-clone portfolio. The CS degree still opens the most doors per application — at 4 years and the highest price. One cloud certificate maximum before job #1 (AWS, $100–150), and only after two real projects exist.
Where you land after: first role (junior dev, QA automation, support engineering) → mid-level → senior. The ceiling Masha scores 10/10 is real: the BLS top 10% of developers earn over $214,670.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
ONE STACK NO WANDERING	PROJECT #1 SHIP IT	AI WORKFLOW REVIEW IT	PROJECT #2 JOB-SHAPED	APPLY WIDE 5 DOORS	INTERVIEWS PROOF TALK

STEP 1 — One stack, no wandering

FREE · DAY 1

- Pick ONE stack: JavaScript/TypeScript for maximum job volume, or Python if you aim at data/automation. Switching stacks is how beginners lose months.
- Day 1, under 30 minutes: create a GitHub account and write down — in a plain text file — the one small tool you wish existed for your own life or job. That becomes Project #1. Then do lesson one of a structured free path: freecodecamp.org or CS50.

STEP 2 — Project #1 — finished beats beautiful

FREE

- Build the tool from day 1: small, finished, deployed (live link), with a README that says what it does and what you learned.
- Learn Git properly this month: branches, pull requests, readable commit messages. Commit daily — the history is future evidence.

STEP 3 — The AI-native workflow

THE 2026 SKILL

- Rebuild one feature of Project #1 with an AI coding assistant, the way hired juniors now work: prompt → review the output line by line → write tests for it → fix what the AI got wrong.
- Document what the AI did badly, in the README. In 2026 interviews this story is a hiring signal, not a confession.

STEP 4 — Project #2 — aimed at a job family

FREE

- Choose by target door: a small full-stack app with login + database (web dev), an automated test suite for a public app (QA track), or a troubleshooting/write-up portfolio (support engineering).
- Contribute one small pull request to an open-source project. Documentation fixes count. Merged PRs are experience a certificate can't fake.

STEP 5 — Apply wide — five doors, not one

WEEKS 9-12

- The title "Junior Software Developer" is the most contested door in tech right now. Also apply to: QA automation, support engineering at SaaS companies, junior roles at banks/insurers/healthcare/local firms, internships and apprenticeships, freelance overflow work.
- 5–10 applications a week, resume built around the two projects and their links — not coursework. One conversation a week with a working developer (meetup, Discord, LinkedIn): ask about their codebase, not for a job.

STEP 6 — Interview readiness PROOF, OUT LOUD

- Drill what employers still test: explain your own code out loud, one easy data-structures problem a day, a 2-minute story per project — "what broke, how I found it".
- Optional, only now: ONE AWS certificate (Cloud Practitioner $100 or Developer Associate $150) — a supporting signal for QA/support/DevOps-track doors, never a substitute for the projects.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- ☐ Day 1 (under 30 min): GitHub account; your Project #1 written down; lesson one done.
- ☐ Days 1–14: one stack, one structured path, daily commits — no wandering.
- ☐ Days 15–45: Project #1 shipped and deployed; then rebuilt once with the AI-native workflow, tests included.
- ☐ Days 46–60: Project #2 aimed at one job family + one open-source contribution.
- ☐ Days 61–90: applications out across all five doors; interview drills running. Day-90 deliverable: 2 deployed projects, a readable GitHub, 1 target job family — a credible candidate, not a job guarantee.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ EXPERIENCED DEVELOPERS DON’T REPRODUCE IN THE SERVER ROOM. BE THE JUNIOR WHO ARRIVES AI-FLUENT. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Numbers: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook — Software Developers, QA Analysts and Testers (May 2025). Junior-market evidence: Stanford Digital Economy Lab, "Canaries in the Coal Mine?" (ADP payroll data); SignalFire State of Tech Talent (via published coverage); IZA discussion paper on junior vs senior postings (Lightcast data). Entry salaries: Indeed salary data, October 2026. Bootcamp tuition and outcomes: Course Report data via 2026 ROI analyses (self-reported outcomes; audited CIRR-style figures run lower). Certificate prices: AWS certification program.